

The Thomas Brothers' Report

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As a history student at California State University, San Marcos, currently interning as a Museum Archival at Escondido History Center, I have analyzed historical photographs of Thomas' family members using bulletins to contextualize their significance. This report aims to list the chronological order of the historical events that the Thomas brothers acted before and after moving to Escondido, CA.

Report:

- Thomas Brother's Letters
- Thomas Family's Letters during the late 1960s.
 - 1966
 - Sept. 5th
 - From Maggie to Frances
 - Written on a paper that has an inscription "MRS. J. A. MACKECHNIE • 3161 MENLO DRIVE • GLENDALE 8, CALIFORNIA"
 - The letter is written the following:
 - "Dear Frances. Here are the letters – some of contents containing information and questions about First National Bank and R. A. Thomas (my father) of San Diego.
 - The information Frances B. Ryan wants now is about the Thomas Bros. and Escondido. Right here si where I talbed to yore!" So to repeat myself –

your grandfather, birthdate, where - and date of death.

- Have fun wading throu the letters – six pages – and I would like to have them returned to me.

- Love and I hope we could get together soon.

Maggie

- The order I have the Thomas Bros listed is

- Richard A. Thomas
- John R. “”
- George R. “”
- William W. “”
- Charles E. “”

- If your mother knows different, have here speak us

- 1968

- June 2nd

- Frances and Lewis Ryan to Orletta

- This letter is written in the following:

- “Hi Orletta:

- Thought you’d like to see a copy of our EARLY DAYSm – we introduced the Thomas Brothers to the Escondidians today. After this the name Thomas Bros., which will appear often, will be understood. Lewis had a prostate gland

removal operation in March. He got along just fine to get back to normal.

- How's Earl? If our men are going to get down we women have to keep up – no?
- Hope you are both on top – and keep there.
- Are you coming our way again?
- Sincerely, Frances + Lewis
- The signatures are tracings of their own handwriting taken from an old Escondido signature.”

- 1970

- July 22nd

- A letter from Virginia to Orletta:

- “Dearest Orletta,
 - Well, Becky, the seasons second hurricane behaved it paralleled our coast for a couple of days but stayed out in the Gulf so that we only got some wind and rain. May they all fade away as well.
 - We have been reading some of our old copies of Desert Magazine. Of course I think of you. We know that desert like a book. We take the Los Angeles Examiner as we like thier columnists. They often write of the desert and Salton Sea area. When they get into tales of the past they often misstate

things. Doubtless they go by the best they hear. But you and I could set them right, if we wished.

Remember the fish that used to feed on the garbage dumped from the trains passing on the bridge over part of the Sea? The crews had instructions wherever practical to dispose of the garbage that way. It gave a point of interest for the passengers, as the fish had so little to eat that they piled up in a mass over the food. It helped support a good fish population and this was a boom for the Mexicans and Indians living around there. The latter was Father's main concern. He couldn't talk much Mexican, but his protective thought was something they understood. He had the finest safety record of any railroad for years and years, and it was because he took time to talk to the section foremen, the track walkers, the little-station agents, and even some professional hobos. They knew the road from the ties and rails end and when they became concerned it was a great day for the safety of the great trains. Railroading is a teamwork job.

- Glad that Father did not see the end of passenger service. He long ago had plans which would have

made travelling more pleasant, especially for women, - and infinitely more pleasant and were more interested in the private care than to travelling greats, such as Paderewski who had his car abroad, then in the roaming school teachers and mothers with children. The greats were the first to take to the planes, and soon there was no 'silk stocking' passenger trade. Since many people do not like to fly anyway, it is possible that good management could have salvaged much passenger travel. Father wanted to put in cars for women with children, so that all occupants would have children. Also he wanted to put in cars for women only. Both types of cars would have had stewardesses, R.N.s and he would have had an inexpensive diner, with low priced tabled hotel meals, and a snack bar. Too rigid in the head office: As Father said, women who needed help account illness or handicap, did not want even the finest (and there were angels among the porters) to help them dress and get to the restroom etc. A stewardess would have appealed to so many.

- Remember what fine porters and cooks Father had on his car? They liked the private car service as the tips were terrific. When Father met some distinguished person and had him aboard his car a trip there was of course no Pullman fee. But the distinguished and valuable to the railroad person generally tipped the men most generously. Then there was a prestige of being a crew on a private car. Many were Masons and they attended lodge in other cities wherever there were colored lodges. It usually meant a fine type of men as the Masonic standards are high. Most U.S. presidents have also been Masons. We were thrilled to see near Washington the lodge where George Washington was a member, -- one of many illustrious men.
- Did you ever think of writing a biography of your Father? He was so outstanding. Father referred to him as the Prince. I recall some wonderful tales that your Dad used to tell us, and they were true. The best thing I remember was that he did not go out and wantonly shoot buffalo etc, like Buffalo Bill. That man was a curse to the land. A few years ago Louis and I were suddenly trapped on a narrow road

by a migration of buffalo to their winter range. It was in South Dakota. We became infatuated with the intelligence of the buffalo, and their associates the prong horn antelope. They have a mutual club, the buffalo provide the protection and the antelope the eyes that see enemies. We began to study buffalo and found it a wide subject. We spent all our remaining time in that area watching the herd. Their care for each other reached deep understanding and compassion. Will tell you about some things when we see you. We just picked out a small overlook and spent days watching the herd. Other drivers who interfered with the herd or tried to run them off the road wound up victims of a stampede so the Rangers had to fence off the road. Too bad. It was a great place for one who loves animals.

- Well honey, Time to get dinner. Wish you both were with us.
- Lovingly Virginia”